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Panama Francis

Drummer David "Panama" Francis has been performing professionally since the 1930's. A native of Miami, David played his first engagements with the Florida Collegians and in New York with Tab Smith. Later gigs with Billy Hicks, Roy Eldridge, Lucky Millinder and Cab Calloway made him a familiar and sought-after drummer for both recordings and live shows. The studios in New York City have called on Panama frequently since the 1950's and he has played on hundreds of Jazz, Rhythm & Blues and early Rock records. In later years he has led the Savoy Sultans and been honored by the Rhythm & Blues Foundation. He is a founding member of the Statesmen of Jazz and can be seen at jazz festivals across the country.

Panama was interviewed in Los Angeles by Michael Woods on September 1, 1995.

MW: We are filming interviews with America's greatest musicians for Hamilton Jazz, Hamilton College Jazz Archives. We have with us today one of the most outstanding drummers in all of jazz, Panama Francis. Hi.

PF: Howdy.

MW: Tell us how you got started playing the drums.

PF: Well I was asked by my parents what I wanted for Christmas — what Santa Claus should bring me for Christmas — and I told them I wanted a drum. At the time I was four years old. And so they bought me a drum for Christmas. And so that's where it started and ever since then that's all it's been — the drum.

MW: Where did you grow up?

PF: I grew up in Miami, Florida.

MW: And tell us about how you learned this music. There weren't any universities that taught jazz at that time, were there?

PF: Well to me, maybe a lot of people won't like it, but I am under the impression that jazz was a music that just happened. It wasn't something that was laid out or thought about, just like, you know, like with classical music. Nobody sat down and thought it out, it just happened. You know I mean there's such a thing as a gift from God. I mean God give you that gift. Like he gave me a gift. I never had no formal training. I just picked up, as I say, at the age of four picked up a pair of sticks and started playing and I've been playing ever since.

MW: But you are gifted.

PF: Well, yeah, that's what I say. You know I mean you get this thing, I mean you're born with it I think you know, that this is what you're going to do. And so that's what happened to me. I mean I could hear something one time and I could play it. In fact that's

one reason why I'm not a teacher, because I don't have the patience to teach anybody because I, you know, it came easy to me. I mean to me it's like eating. Like a lot of people have asked me, which I mean this doesn't work for everybody, but I practice on the bandstand. I don't practice. When I get up on the bandstand, that's when I practice. And every time I get up there I learn something new.

MW: That's a perfectly valid experience, to be learning on the bandstand.

PF: Yeah, well I haven't stopped learning.

MW: Do different musicians that play different ways 'cause you to react certain ways as a drummer?

PF: Well yes. I am very competitive. In fact when I worked with Roy Eldridge, he was of the same mentality. And we used to go out and look for jam sessions and look for guys to cut you know. Because back then it was just like sports. I mean music was like sports. You and I can be the best of friends. And you play drums, I play drums. But when we got on the bandstand it was a different ball game. Everything went out the window. I mean I'm competing with you and you are competing with me. And that's why, you know, there were so many new ideas and things that was going on and everybody had their own individual style, because they were themselves. You know they didn't study with someone that everybody has to do it the same way. I mean like in the south a lot of the musicians, they didn't have any music teachers. They learned by trial and errors. So you might see a guy that's a trumpet player, and he'd have both jaws out like this you know, like Dizzy Gillespie. That's because I mean when he started out he didn't have nobody to tell him that that was wrong. But he got results doing this.

MW: You know tell us about your concept of what the drummer does in the ensemble. What role does the drummer bring to jazz music?

PF: Well to me, the drummer's role, he is timekeeper. It's not the bass player or the piano player, the drummer. The drummer is the basic in jazz. He is the basic man in jazz. But what has happened, it's not easy playing bass drum. That's why if you hear the different bands and things, everything is top, everything is on top. You don't hear nothing at the bottom. There's no bottom other than the bass. But when I was coming up, the drum and the bass player worked together as a team. This bass drum and the bass fiddle coincide with each other. And the bass drum was playing where he didn't overpower the bass. It was felt, not heard, it was felt. And you don't learn that overnight, I mean, being a drummer. See that's another thing. You have to pay your dues. I mean it took me seven years to learn how to control the bass drum that I'd over play it or, and I'd keep time. Seven years. And if you was to feel this it's nothing but muscle you know? Because of all those years of doing this. But that's not easy. It's not easy to do this and keep it steady, keep it going. And you start a tempo and you end up at that tempo. You don't start under

or over, you start at that tempo. But that takes years of experience. But today I mean the young drummers, you know I mean they're learning all the rudiments. Yeah they all can play some of the greatest solos that you want to hear. I mean they frighten me with the solos that they play, because they know the rudiments and things. But when they're supposed to do the job that they're supposed to be doing, they don't do it. They're all over the drums. They're not just playing [scats] playing the time, keeping the swinging.

MW: Keeping the band swinging. I mean that's an art in itself, isn't it?

PF: Yes. Well look I take great pride, in fact I play solos now because I have to because people want you to play solos. But I mean when I was coming up, I mean we took pride in how we swung the band, how we made the people dance. 'Cause the music actually was created for dancing. It wasn't created to sit and listen to. See that's one of the things that I object to, that they've taken the music and, in a way, they've taken the rhythm out of it, for one thing, they've taken the rhythm — there's no more rhythm section. We used to have a rhythm section rehearsal, just like the saxophone section rehearsed and the trumpet section and the trombone. The rhythm section had rehearsal. We'd have an arrangement and we'd say well we'll play two beats here and we'll play four beats here, and we'll go into four here, and that. And that's why those records sound the way that they do, those old records. Because there was a rhythm section there, which doesn't happen today. The guy that's playing the rhythm is the bass player. He's got the whole load on himself. Now everybody else is doing, you know, what they do, doing their thing, yeah.

MW: When music is played for dancing, the rhythm in the music itself has to speak to the dancers, doesn't it?

PF: Yeah. Well see I mean my conception, and I was the youngest one in all the bands I worked in, so I never was a teenager. I spent all my time with older musicians, I mean all my time was spent with older musicians. So I got many a stories and I heard of many a stories and like I mean I used to hang out with Eubie Blake you know. I mean Eubie Blake was old enough to be my grandfather, I mean great grandfather. But that's who I hung out with. And right now, even now, I mean I meet people that's my age group, and I get bored with them. I'd rather be around an older person or a younger person. Like I have a lot of fun with my daughters. I have a lot of fun with older people. But people in my age group, a lot of them is a drag, man. And that's because I was always around older people. And I spent my time there. And like they used the word "jazz." See I remember a time that the word jazz was a dirty word. You know, it just became respectable say in the last forty years, forty-five years. Up until then I mean jazz was, I mean the word jazz was related to sex or bull. And that's what the black musicians would call it. The black musicians would label jazz musicians because they didn't play the music like classical

musicians did. And I mean even today, like the older musicians I know, it was an insult to call them a jazz musician. I mean Duke Ellington and Count Basie and Roy Eldridge and these people, they'll tell you right off hand, I play music. Don't label me no jazz musician, 'cause I can, where I mean with me I have played Bar Mitzvahs, I've played Polkas, I've played Waltzes, I've played Tangos, I mean you name it, I'm prostituted, long as you gonna pay me I'll play. So I mean don't label me a jazz musician. I'm a musician. But this was a put down that was put upon the black musicians by the classical musicians that, because this music was syncopated and they had a rhythm section and it wasn't like European classical music, they put it down.

MW: But now, the term now has become a compliment.

PF: Well because it's accepted and people are making money off it. That's why. Simple as that. It's acceptable now because everybody's making money off it. But I remember the time that you played this music, even in the black families, there were a lot of black families that would say get that devil music out of here. They didn't want to hear that music you know. Although this happens because whoever the father or the mother was, they were working for some people and they called it devil music, so they accepted it as that.

MW: Tell us about the drums as a musical instrument. How do you get different tones and sounds out the drums?

PF: Well in the first place...

MW: Because it's not just a percussion instrument.

PF: It is a percussion instrument. That's what it is.

MW: Yes but you get many different tone colors out of it.

PF: Well I mean you tune it up. You very seldom see me without this [drum key]. I've always got it. So I tune up the drums. And I tune them to different sounds. And like with my bass drum, up until in recent years, I used tympani heads on the bass drum. So I used to tune my bass drum to G so it could blend with the bass fiddle. And see they don't do that anymore. The guys, I don't know. Something happened somewhere down the line that it's, you know, it's been changed. And they you know speak about, well you don't have to play any bass drum, you just use the bass drum to accent. That's crap. The bass drum is very important. But that's the reason why when I play, I look out in that audience, and if I don't see nobody doing, well patting their foot or something, then I ain't swinging. I'm not swinging. Something is missing. I'm not getting to them. But if I see one person out there patting their foot or shaking their head, I play for them. Forget about the other people, I'll play for that one person. Because that's where my inspiration comes from. And I love to watch people dance, because that really inspires me, to watch people dance.

MW: Tell us some of the big bands that you played with.

PF: Well I started out with a band in Miami when I was fourteen years old, called George Kelly and the Cavaliers. And I was with them until I was eighteen, and I went to Tampa to join a band that was fronted by a guy named Charlie Brantley. And then I left and went to New York. And I did something in New York that very few musicians or very few people in show business have done. I got to New York on a Tuesday and went to work Sunday and I never looked back. I was like one of the first ones of my peers to leave home. Everybody was afraid to leave to go to New York because they heard all these fantastic stories about these fantastic musicians in New York and they were afraid to go. But after I went, then here comes Cannonball and George Kelly and all the rest of them, then everybody followed me up there. But I was the one that led the way. And I'm not doing one of these things, but I did. Because everybody else was afraid to leave. I didn't know anything, I was stupid anyway. A young dumb kid I guess. Because I sit back and I think about some of the dumb things that I've done. But you can imagine, I mean here I am at thirteen I'm working in night clubs. At fourteen I'm on the road, and experiencing things that a man in his twenties would be experiencing.

MW: Tell us about how it was like, the travel, the pay, the lifestyle of working with the traveling band.

PF: Now up until I went north, I mean the pay was low, because well in the south the salaries was low. Nobody was making no big bucks. So I mean the salaries was low. Like we got a dollar and a half a night for playing a gig. But with a dollar and a half, you can go to the store the next day and buy a dollar and a half worth of food.

MW: What would a dollar and a half buy at that time?

PF: Well you could get three pounds of fish for a dime.

MW: Wow.

PF: You could get spare ribs or pork chops or steak for a quarter a pound. String beans and collard greens and all that, people used to throw that away. You know, so it was, a dollar and a half went a long way. Like room rent, people used to charge like three dollars a week for a room you know. And see there's one thing I mean you see me like this now, I came up in this type of school. Where a musician looked the part of a musician. You didn't dress like any and everybody. You stood out like a sore thumb in the crowd. Everybody knew who the musician was. Because he was the guy that was dressed. He had on a shirt and a tie. Like I used to change suits sometimes three times a day. I owned over thirty suits of clothes. But nowadays, it kind of bugs me to see a musician walk up on the bandstand with sneakers on and a sports shirt. Well, that's the way it is today, but when I was coming up, you knew who the musician was. He didn't look like any and everybody in the neighborhood.

MW: Have you played in Europe? Tell us about playing outside the United States.

PF: Well in Europe it's a different ball game. The people in Europe, well almost all the people that come to a jazz festival or jazz clubs are intellectuals or students. And they feel that this is the only art form that American gave to the world was this music. And so they accept us, in fact, there was a time that they felt that nobody white could play jazz, because everybody black was playing it. There was a time that there were very few white guys that even thought of playing jazz. Because like I say it was a lowdown. You know there was one time they called it "whorehouse music" you know. It had every kind of derogatory name that you could think of, and white musicians didn't want to be associated with that kind of music. It wasn't until 19 what 1919 or 1918 that with the rhythm, the Original Dixieland Band that came on the scene, and that's when white guys started playing it. But before then they didn't play that. Everybody was for the symphony. Everybody was trying for the symphony. blacks too. The only thing, they wasn't accepted. They couldn't join the symphony because they said they played it with a jazz feeling. So they wasn't able to get into the symphony orchestra. So there was a lot guys that learned cello and violin, like Coleman Hawkins was a cello player. But he couldn't get a job in the symphony orchestra. Well I mean in fact the black musicians are responsible for the saxophones. Because the classical trained musician called it a bastard instrument, because they didn't use it in the symphony. And they were responsible for the saxophone, I mean being accepted, it was the black musicians, Coleman Hawkins and those kind of people.

MW: Let me ask you, how did you get the nickname "Panama?"

PF: I've been asked that so many times. I wish I had a dollar for every time I've been asked that. What happened, I joined Roy Eldridge. In fact I met Roy at a jam session, 'cause as I say I was very competitive and I used to go looking for jam sessions. And so I went to this jam session and Roy Eldridge heard me. And he liked the way that I played behind him. And his drummer was leaving the band to join Chic Webb's band because Chic was in the hospital. He hadn't died yet but he left to join Chic's band. And so Roy was looking for a drummer. And he heard me in the jam session. So he asked me who was I working with. I told him I wasn't working with anybody because I was just gigging around with I mean everybody. So he asked me if I would like to join his band. I didn't even know who he was. And I told him yes. So he said, well I think this was on like a Thursday night. He said "well we have rehearsals on Tuesday. Can you make the rehearsals?" So I said "yeah." So I'm there setting my drums up when Joe Glaser walked in there, 'cause Joe Glaser had Roy under contract. And he used to hire the musicians for Louis, so he had hired Sid Catlett to play with Roy. And I guess Roy, not being like Louis, I mean he didn't accept any and everybody to play with him, he wanted to be comfortable with whoever he worked with. So I'm there setting the drums up and Joe

Glaser walks in. And he asked for Big Sid. So Roy said "I don't know where he is." So he said "well who is that setting up the drums there?" And without batting an eye, he just turned around and said "oh, that's Panama" 'cause I had on a Panama hat. It was the summertime and I had just come from Florida, and that was the style in Florida, a Panama hat. So I had on a Panama hat. And I was too scared to tell the fellows, you know here I am in the big league now. Too scared to tell the guys that my name was David. And so the name stuck. That's how I got the name Panama.

MW: That's great. Tell us what you know of Louis Armstrong.

PF: I don't know too much about Louis Armstrong. I knew him 'cause see I was always in the position where I was always working, I didn't have, I mean I didn't have too much layoff time, and when Joe Glaser approached me about joining Louis, I asked him for a price. And he said "well no I don't pay that kind of money." So I said "well forget about it." Because I was independent enough that I could say that. So that's why I never worked with him. But I would meet him, like I meet you or somebody else and we'd talk and stuff, but not to play with him.

MW: But you have played with some of the great Rhythm & Blues artists.

PF: Oh, well, I'll tell you about that. Two years ago, in '93, they honored me, the Rhythm & Blues Foundation it's called, out of Washington, D.C. They honored me for my contribution to Rhythm & Blues. But I was put down by the jazz musicians for playing Rhythm & Blues. Because that was the lowest — I mean they would record that music but they wasn't too proud about it. And by me playing in the church when I was like nine years old, I used to play the Church of God, that was my gig on Sundays, I used to get fifty cents on Sundays for playing in church. I mean Rhythm & Blues came from the church.

MW: Yes it did.

PF: I mean the only difference is the words were changed, but the music is the same. So that's how I knew so much about Rhythm & Blues. And so I was called by the jazz musicians, I was called that Rock 'n Roll drummer. It was a put down. Like we'd be in the bar at Jim and Andy's and I'd walk in the door and they'd say "ohhh, here comes this Rock 'n Roller." Although they didn't realize how much money I was making, but when they found out how much money I was making, they was knocking the door down to make them records. But anyhow, two years ago they honored me, they gave me fifteen thousand dollars and a plaque. And I went to make my acceptance speech and all I could say was "ladies and gentlemen" and I bust out in tears, uncontrollable. Because I was hurt by the jazz musicians who knew me and knew that I worked in bands and heard me in jam sessions, and they went along with the white musicians who labeled me a Rock 'n Roll musician. Because they never heard me play no jazz, because I was in Harlem all the

time see, with the big bands. So they didn't get a chance to hear me on 52nd Street. So they thought that this was all I could do, you know, that I was only able to play Rock 'n Roll. And my friends and my so-called friends and brothers that knew different, never stood up and said well no man, he can play something else. I never got called for a big band date, I never got called for a jazz date. Very few jazz dates I did because of that. That was a label that was laid on me that wasn't fair, because, I mean, I was able to play, you know, at the age of thirteen I was playing in bands. I wasn't playing no Rhythm & Blues — I was playing in bands, playing arrangements and things. But I knew how to play this music, because I used to play in the church. Just like Rhythm & Blues became Rock 'n Roll. I mean there was a disc jockey in Chicago named Al Benson that when he introduced his show, when he came on the air, he used to say "we're gonna rock and we're gonna roll this evening, children." He sounded like a minister. And that's where it came from. That's where the Rock 'n Roll came from. Alan Freed picked it up from Al Benson, 'cause he thought that's what the music was you know. It's just like the word "funk." That was a dirty word with black people. You told somebody to "funk" you'd be ready to fight. But the jazz critic heard the term being used by musicians, and they thought it was hip and it caught on. So they said "he sure plays funky, doesn't he." I remember the time you used that word that you're liable to get your teeth knocked out of you. I mean that wasn't a nice word.

MW: Listen, this is just absolutely fabulous, giving us some insights into the way that you play the drums and the way that you look at the concepts of jazz. For our students that will be watching these tapes, if you could give a word of wisdom to up and coming drummers, something that will help them understand the real nature of this music, leave us with a word of wisdom.

PF: What I would tell them, that the basic instrument which has been taken out of jazz, the basic instrument is the bass drum. And the bass drum coincides with the bass fiddle. They play together as a team. And that's what gives the band that bottom that you don't hear today. It was the bass drum. So if there's any young drummer, that to me, that really wants to play drums the way I think or feel the way they should be played, he should learn how to play that bass drum, how to master that bass drum. And it doesn't happen overnight. It takes years to perfect playing the bass drum that you don't overpower the bass fiddle, the bass violin. So that's the advice that I would give. Because in the first place, the drums is not a solo instrument. It's a rhythm instrument. That's what it is. Rhythm first, and then the solos.

MW: That's beautiful. That is beautiful. Thank you so much, and this has been a marvelous interview. Hamilton College is developing a jazz archive that I think will be fabulous with interviews like this. Thank you.

300 PF: Okay. You're welcome.